14.4 Identity Governance and Administration (IGA) and policy governance

Policies control how access is granted; identity governance controls who can be considered for access in the first place. Together, they form the two sides of an organization's access assurance system: one overseeing entitlements and the other managing authorization logic.

Identity Governance and Administration (IGA) refers to the processes and tools organizations use to manage digital identities, entitlements, and access rights across various systems. Besides controlling access, IGA also ensures that identities are properly authenticated and maintained throughout their lifecycle, tracking credentials, enforcing strong authentication policies, and validating identity assurance levels. IGA systems monitor who has access to which resources, streamline access requests and approvals, and conduct regular certifications to verify that both identity and access remain appropriate and trustworthy over time. Modern IGA platforms also support separation of duties, policy-based approvals, and reporting for regulatory compliance. For an introduction, see the sidebar "IGA in context."

At ACME, IGA was the company's initial step toward organized access management. Long before adopting Cedar for dynamic authorization, the IT team implemented an IGA platform to manage joiner–mover–leaver processes, provisioning employees into systems, and managing application access through group memberships. These workflows worked well for internal systems, but as ACME's Customer Collaboration platform evolved into a multi-tenant SaaS product, the static entitlements in IGA became insufficient. Access decisions increasingly relied on context—customer relationships, project roles, data classifications, and device trust levels—factors that IGA alone could not assess.

Policy governance filled that gap. Where IGA manages who can hold access, policy governance manages how that access is evaluated at runtime. Together, they form a closed feedback loop:

- IGA defines the authoritative source of identity attributes and entitlements.